

Sample Short Assignment Questions

Instructions

The in class assignment will have *four* questions, *one* from each of the topics below. In each case, it will be one of the three questions listed here. If you prep answers to all three, you can't be surprised.

We're expecting you to spend about 8 minutes on each question, for just over a 30 minute assignment. That's about 200-300 words realistically.

Memory

Option One

Jo believes that the Battle of Hastings was in 1066. She is right. She has believed it since she was small, and she cannot remember where she learned it or why she first believed it. Give the best reason for saying Jo's belief is justified, and the best reason for saying it is not. Then say which you find more convincing, and why.

Option Two

Two different claims both go by the name "preservationism":

1. That a belief which enters memory justified keeps that justification; and
2. That memory cannot create justification which was not there already.

Explain how somebody could accept the first of these and reject the second. Describe a case in which the difference between them shows up.

Option Three

In class, a list of words was read out, and a large number of people afterwards reported having heard a word that was never said. Explain what this is supposed to show about how memory works, and why it matters for the question of whether our memory beliefs are justified.

Testimony

Option One

A reductionist says that testimony is not a source of knowledge in its own right, because you always have to check whether the speaker is reliable before you are entitled to believe them. Explain Datta's reply, and say what the reply is meant to show about the reductionist's principle.

Option Two

Several contemporary philosophers who take Datta's side in debates about testimony are moved by the following argument. We cannot, even in principle, check everything we are told. We are only required to do what we can, at least in principle, do. So we cannot be required to check everything we are told. Explain how the idea of epistemic vigilance is supposed to answer this argument.

Option Three

Two people disagree about testimony. One has the view we called reductionism; they say you should believe what a stranger tells you only if you have some positive reason to think they are reliable. The other has the view we called anti-reductionism; they say you should believe them unless you have some positive reason to doubt them. Describe a situation in which these two give different advice. Then explain why the disagreement between them is narrower than it first looks.

Anderson

Option One

Anderson argues that a person who cannot assess a scientific claim can still assess the scientists making it. Explain why she thinks the second task is easier than the first. Then give one reason to doubt that it is as easy as she suggests.

Option Two

Describe what Anderson means by ‘dialogic irrationality’. Why is this kind of ‘irrationality’ easier to identify than other kinds?

Option Three

Occasionally, the scientific community as a whole gets things wrong. For instance, for a long time the conventional wisdom was that stomach ulcers were caused by stress and stomach acid; the real reason was bacterial infection. What does Anderson’s view recommend that ordinary people believe in these cases? Is this recommendation reasonable?

Nguyen

Option One

Sam only ever encounters arguments for one side of a political question. He has never met a serious argument for the other side, and it has never occurred to him that there is one. Mia has met the arguments for the other side many times. She was told, long before she met them, that people who make those arguments are paid to make them, and she has found this to be true of several of them.

Someone hands each of them a well-argued piece from the other side. Say what Nguyen would expect to happen in each case, and why the two cases come apart.

Option Two

Part of what makes an echo chamber hard to leave is that members are told in advance what outsiders will say, and why they will say it. Explain why this technique works better when the warning is true than when it is false.

Option Three

Someone says: “The way out of an echo chamber is to stop relying on other people and think for yourself.” Describe why Nguyen rejects this, say why you think he’s right to reject it, and defend your answer.